

The Arctic is changing shipping

送信者: POLITICO Pro Morning Mobility Europe 受信日時: 2026-09-14 14:02

【要点】

- ・フィンランドは本日、EU指導者を集めて北極圏の重要性を高めるための会議を開催し、ロシアの軍事的脅威と中国の進出、気候変動による海運ルート変化への対応を協議している。
- ・フィンランドは軍事的移動性、東西ネットワーク、重要インフラ保護、海上安全について、より強いEUの支援を求めており、北極の輸送回廊とコンクリート船砕氷能力の強化を主張している。
- ・EUは北極圏を遠隔地域から戦略的中核へと位置づけを変え、防衛やエネルギー、通信、貿易など複数の領域で具体的なプロジェクトへの資金投下を進める必要がある。
- ・砕氷船の共有をEUレベルで進めることが検討されており、フィンランドは世界の砕氷船設計の約80%、建造の約60%を担当している。

【メール原文】

Presented by BMW Group By JORDYN DAHL with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK
— Finland is gathering European leaders today to push the Arctic

Presented by BMW Group

By JORDYN DAHL

with TOMMASO LECCA and MARTINA SAPIO

PRESENTED BY

View in your browser or listen to audio

SNEAK PEEK

— Finland is gathering European leaders today to push the Arctic higher up the EU's agenda as China's growing presence and climate-driven changes to northern shipping routes reshape the region.

— Two groups are pushing the Irish presidency to weaken the IAA's local content requirements for electric vehicles because of the potential impact on buses.

— The Czech Republic wants to take a more cautious approach to Buy European requirements, saying the bloc needs China and others for its automotive sector.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

DRIVING THE DAY

EUROPE LOOKS NORTH: EU leaders are in Rovaniemi, Finland, today to tackle Arctic issues, including transport links, military mobility, maritime safety and even jointly owned icebreakers.

Why now: Finnish Prime Minister Petteri Orpo will host leaders including Germany's Friedrich Merz, Poland's Donald Tusk, Denmark's Mette Frederiksen and European Council President António Costa, alongside top EU diplomat Kaja Kallas and other EU officials. The aim is to strengthen the EU's common strategic approach to the Arctic as Russia's military posture, China's growing presence and climate-driven changes to northern shipping routes reshape the region.

Transport at the center: A Finnish official told Martina that Helsinki wants more EU backing for military mobility, east-west links from Finland to Sweden and Norway, critical infrastructure protection and improved maritime safety. Finland also called for closer European cooperation on Arctic transport corridors and icebreaking capacity, arguing that northern connectivity is increasingly tied to security of supply and crisis preparedness.

The bigger strategic shift: Helsinki's message is that the Arctic should no longer be treated as a remote regional concern. The North is becoming central to Europe's defense, raw-materials security, energy resilience, telecoms, satellite services and trade. That means the EU should move from simply acknowledging the region's importance to putting money into concrete projects, including transport links, critical infrastructure and industrial capabilities.

Icebreakers as strategy: One idea is to explore European joint ownership or joint use of icebreakers — a capability where Finland has unusual weight and is one of the world's leading producers. Finnish companies have designed around 80% of the world's icebreakers and built roughly 60%, including for the United States , while more than 95% of Finland's foreign trade in goods moves by sea.

Russia and China in the background: Russia is considered the main security threat in the region, but Finland also wants a more realistic European assessment of China's expanding Arctic role. That concern is increasingly linked to transport, as the Northern Sea Route running along Russia's northern coast is becoming more relevant for commercial shipping, and northern infrastructure is now viewed through both an economic and security lens.

Money question: Helsinki is also tying the Arctic debate to negotiations over the EU's next long-term budget. The argument is that strategic northern projects — from cross-border transport and military mobility to satellites and icebreaking — will require EU-level public financing alongside private capital.

What comes out: The summit is expected to adopt a joint declaration aimed at steering the EU's Arctic policy, set to be revealed on Oct. 20, as well as future financing priorities. Helsinki wants the message to be simple: the Arctic is no longer a niche northern issue, but a European security, logistics and resilience question.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

* Sponsor: BMW Group

* The advertisement is linked to the EU Automotive Package and the Industrial Accelerator Act.

More information about political advertising [here](#) .

URBAN TRANSPORT

BUY EUROPEAN BUS RULES FACE PUSHBACK: The International Road Transport Union and the European Metropolitan Transport Authorities are urging the Irish Council presidency to soften parts of the Industrial Accelerator Act's proposed "Buy European" rules for electric vehicles, warning the current text could create inconsistent exemptions and leave bus operators exposed if European manufacturers fail to deliver.

Background: In a letter seen exclusively by POLITICO, the groups wrote to Irish Enterprise Minister Peter Burke and Commissioners Apostolos Tzitzikostas and Stéphane Séjourné.

The 2035 problem: Under the proposal, non-EU-origin vehicles already operating under public service contracts could continue only until the end of 2035. IRU and EMTA say that could force authorities to retire fully functional electric buses early, even if those vehicles were bought before the new rules existed. Denmark alone estimates more than 1,000 existing electric buses could be affected. The groups want those vehicles allowed to stay in service for their full operational lifetime.

Too many rulebooks: The letter also argues that exemptions from EU-origin requirements are drafted differently for public procurement and public support schemes, meaning the same vehicle could qualify under one system but not the other. IRU and EMTA want the derogations harmonized to cut uncertainty and administrative burden.

And then there's delivery risk: The groups say delays and partial or failed deliveries from European electric-bus suppliers are already frequent, leaving authorities facing network disruption and operators exposed to penalties they cannot always pass back to manufacturers. Their answer is "back-to-back" protection in supply contracts, so costs or penalties caused by supplier delays can be transferred to the responsible manufacturer.

Hidden problem: Chinese-made buses are deeply embedded in Europe's electric-bus fleets. European Bus Data's 2025 market breakdown shows Chinese manufacturers including Foton, BYD, Yutong, King Long, Higer and Golden Dragon taking a substantial share of new electric-bus registrations, alongside European manufacturers. That helps explain IRU and EMTA's warning that abruptly restricting non-EU-origin vehicles could strand buses that authorities bought when European supply was insufficient.

Bottom line: IRU and EMTA say they support strengthening Europe's industrial base and treating electric vehicles as a strategic sector — but argue Buy European rules will only work if they do not punish operators for earlier procurement choices or for supply failures outside their control.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

****A message from BMW Group:** Europe's mobility transition must deliver on three fronts: decarbonization, competitiveness and resilience. In this Q&A , Dr. Frank Niederländer, Vice President for Government Affairs Europe at BMW Group, discusses what Europe needs to get the balance right and keep its industrial base strong.**

* Sponsor: BMW Group

* The advertisement is linked to the EU Automotive Package and the Industrial Accelerator Act.

More information about political advertising here .

CARS

CZECHIA URGES CAUTION ON IAA: The Czech Republic is taking a more cautious approach to the Commission's Buy European push with the Industrial Accelerator Act, Deputy Prime Minister Karel Havlíček told our colleague Tom Schmidtgen on Friday. He warned that the EU needs products from South Korea, the U.K. and China for its automotive sector. The minister added that his country's approach mirrors that of Germany.

Let's talk: Commenting on Paris and Berlin working together to find a joint compromise on the IAA and trade relations with China ahead of October's Council meeting, Havlíček said: "I hope they will reach a good compromise. I don't feel excluded. What matters is the result."

Great minds think alike: Prague is also backing Berlin's approach to trade relations with China, saying the EU should take action against "excess Chinese imports," before calling out Chinese hybrid vehicles as one such target for action. German automaker Volkswagen is similarly urging the Commission to erect trade barriers to stop the influx of hybrids.

Growing coalition: Chancellor Friedrich Merz has also called on trade action, telling our Berlin colleagues earlier this month that Berlin would put forward its trade proposal in October. In Italy, the country's automotive suppliers' lobby wants the Commission to slap 80 percent tariffs on all Chinese cars and parts.

But tread carefully: "China is an opportunity, but at the same time it is also a threat. That's the reality," Havlíček said. "China is beating Europe with European weapons: science, innovation and new technologies." The EU cannot rely solely on trade barriers but must also reduce regulation and high energy prices.

Travel agenda: Havlíček and Prime Minister Andrej Babiš are planning a trip to Beijing in the spring to "restart the relationship." Beijing and Prague have had rocky ties for over four years with the Czech Republic being one of the first EU member states to warn of Chinese economic encroachment and influence efforts. But Babiš's far-right coalition is eager to rebuild bridges with China.

AVIATION

GROUPS PUSH BACK ON REFUELEU AND ESAF: A coalition of more than 20 organizations is urging the EU not to allow electrolytic hydrogen used in biofuel production to be counted toward e-SAF synthetic jet fuel targets created under ReFuelEU Aviation. The "accounting trick ... would establish a dangerous regulatory precedent across the entire transport framework," the group wrote in a letter sent to the Commission this morning and seen in advance by POLITICO.

What's this about: ReFuelEU Aviation sets targets for the synthetic SAF sector beginning in 2030. But major airlines want that date postponed and large fuel suppliers are calling on the Commission to review the penalties they face if production is not ready by the end of the decade.

The danger: The group, which includes green NGO Transport & Environment, Green Transition Denmark and various e-fuel producers, argue that allowing electrolytic hydrogen be used would allow "existing biofuel refiners to claim they are delivering e-fuels, without building new synthetic fuel plants."

PIT STOPS

The number of company cars in Belgium increased 12% over the past five years, local media report , with lower-level positions increasingly getting the benefit.

POLITICAL ADVERTISEMENT

****A message from BMW Group: Europe's automotive industry is entering a crucial decade. As manufacturers navigate electrification, global competition, geopolitical uncertainty and rising energy costs, Europe faces the challenge of delivering decarbonization while strengthening competitiveness and resilience. In this Q&A , POLITICO Studio speaks to Dr. Frank Niederländer, Vice President for Government Affairs Europe at BMW Group, about the choices and conditions that will shape the next phase of Europe's automotive transition. He discusses how Europe can strengthen the industrial base behind the transition, what it will take to build a competitive battery ecosystem and why establishing new capabilities requires the right investment conditions — and time to scale. He also explores why policymakers should look beyond tailpipe emissions to consider the full value chain, and the potential role of renewable fuels alongside electrification. And why the transition will only succeed if it works for consumers and businesses while keeping investment, innovation and value creation in Europe.****

* Sponsor: BMW Group

* The advertisement is linked to the EU Automotive Package and the Industrial Accelerator Act.

More information about political advertising here .

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

How did von der Leyen's 'independence moment' hold up over 12 months?

A review of 40 actionable commitments from her 2025 State of the Union speech shows the Commission president fell well short of transforming Europe, but delivered on the basics.

By Gerardo Fortuna · Sept 13, 2026, 01:56 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Pro Intelligence Connections

2021/0205(COD) Sustainable aviation fuels (ReFuelE...

Discussions within the Council or its preparatory...

This email alert has been sent for your exclusive use as a POLITICO Pro subscriber. Forwarding or reproducing the newsletter without the express, written permission of POLITICO Pro is a violation of the POLITICO Pro license agreement.

This email was sent to shondo@iies.co.jp

[Update settings](#) | [Unsubscribe from this email](#) | [Unsubscribe from all emails](#)

POLITICO SRL · Rue de la Loi 62 · Brussels 1040 · Belgium